Hardinge refers in his dispatch to an ‘outer line’, but dismisses it as unnecessary, as a new, more precise boundary was being discussed. But in Lamb’s and Maxwell’s version of history, this imprecise ‘outer line’ becomes the official Outer Line. According to Phanjoubam, the territory between the Inner Line, which did exist, and the crest of the Himalayas ‘was, for all practical purposes, treated as wild “no-man’s” land till it was claimed officially and, in this case, by the McMahon Line’.[69]

Maxwell also gives the impression that the land beyond Assam was China and he refers to perceived threats in India by ‘an active Chinese presence on the frontier of India’, and that was the reason why the British wanted to expand north.[70] But apart from erecting a few border markers in a remote area in the vicinity of Walong during the brief occupation of Tibet during 1910–12, there were no Chinese officials or soldiers anywhere near India’s northern frontier. Maxell also refers to Tawang as being ‘unchallengeably Tibetan/Chinese’, as if the Tibetans and the Chinese were happily administering the area together.[71] It is not inconceivable that some Chinese merchants did venture into or through Tawang in the early twentieth century, but no government officials from China were ever in that area. Equally misleading is Maxwell’s reference to ‘the sudden collapse of Chinese power in Tibet in 1911–12’.[72] He is, in fact, referring to the brief and failed Chinese occupation of Tibet during those years.

The colonial move into today’s Arunachal Pradesh was prompted by other, more immediate concerns such as tribal raids into the lowlands of Assam, and planters wishing to extend their tea gardens into the hills north of the Brahmaputra. Several of the tribal chiefs north of the Inner Line were paid handsomely by the British Indian government to refrain from raiding the plains, resulting in a mutual dependence between them and the colonial power. The chieftains needed the British to keep outsiders away, and the British ensured themselves of a reasonable loyalty from the tribals by paying them annual subsidies.

Tibet, on the other side of the Himalayas, managed to maintain its de facto independence for decades after the 1913 proclamation by the thirteenth Dalai Lama, and even before that, as Tibet specialist Warren W. Smith points out, ‘the nature of the [imperial] Qing relationship with Tibet was one between states, or between an empire and a semiautonomous state,